

Tianjian Li

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Education

Johns Hopkins University , Ph.D. in Computer Science	Aug 2024 – Present
• Advisor: Daniel Khashabi	
Johns Hopkins University , M.S. in Computer Science	Aug 2022 - May 2024
• Advisor(s): Kenton Murray, Philipp Koehn, Daniel Khashabi	
New York University , B.A. Joint Major in Mathematics and Computer Science	Aug 2017 - May 2021

Industry Experience

Research Scientist Intern , Meta Fundamental AI Research (FAIR) – New York, NY	June 2026 – Sept 2026
• Host: Weizhe Yuan.	
Research Scientist Intern , Meta Fundamental AI Research (FAIR) – Bellevue, WA	May 2025 – Dec 2025
• Host: Tianlu Wang; Manager(s): Jack Lanchantin, Jason Weston.	
Machine Learning Engineer , Baidu Inc. – Beijing, China	Aug 2021 – Jan 2022

First-Authored Publications

Self-Compacting Language Model Agents	[Paper] [Code]
Tianjian Li, Jingyu Zhang, William Jurayj, Xi Wang, Chuanyang Jin, Mehrdad Farajtabar, Eric Nalisnick, Daniel Khashabi. NeurIPS 2026.	
Jointly Reinforcing Diversity and Quality in Language Model Generations	[Paper] [Code]
Tianjian Li, Yiming Zhang, Ping Yu, Swarnadeep Saha, Daniel Khashabi, Jason Weston, Jack Lanchantin, Tianlu Wang. NeurIPS 2026.	
Reasoning over Mathematical Objects: On-Policy Reward Modeling and Test Time Aggregation	[Paper]
Pranjal Aggarwal, Marjan Ghazvininejad, Seungone Kim, Ilia Kulikov, Jack Lanchantin, Xian Li, Tianjian Li [*] , Bo Liu, Graham Neubig, Anaelia Ovalle, Swarnadeep Saha, Sainbayar Sukhbaatar, Sean Welleck, Jason Weston, Chenxi Whitehouse, Adina Williams, Jing Xu, Ping Yu, Weizhe Yuan, Jingyu Zhang, Wenting Zhao. Preprint 2026. <i>[*]Alphabetical order. Lead the section on parallel test-time scaling.</i>	
SimpleMix: Frustratingly Simple Mixing of Off- and On-policy Data in Language Model Preference Learning	[Paper]
Tianjian Li, Daniel Khashabi. ICML 2025.	
Upsample or Upweight: Balanced Training on Heavily Unbalanced Datasets	[Paper] [Video]
Tianjian Li, Weiting Tan, Haoran Xu, Kenton Murray, Daniel Khashabi. NAACL 2025.	
Error Norm Truncation: Robust Training in the Presece of Data Noise in Text Generation Models	[Paper] [Code] [Video]
Tianjian Li, Haoran Xu, Philipp Koehn, Daniel Khashabi, Kenton Murray. ICLR 2024. Spotlight Presentation (367/7304 $\approx$ 5%).	
Why Does Zero-shot Cross-lingual Transfer Fail? An Explanation and a Solution	[Paper]
Tianjian Li, Kenton Murray. ACL 2023 Findings.	

Non-First Authored Publications

ThoughtTrace: Understanding User Thoughts in Real-World LLM Interactions [\[Paper\]](#)

Chuangyang Jin, Binze Li, Haopeng Xie, Cathy Mengying Fang, **Tianjian Li**, Shayne Longpre, Hongxiang Gu, Maximillian Chen, Tianmin Shu.

RLxL Workshop, ICML 2026. **Best Paper Award**.

Many-Tier Instruction Hierarchy in LLM Agents [\[Paper\]](#)

Jingyu Zhang, **Tianjian Li**, William Jurayj, Hongyuan Zhan, Benjamin Van Durme, Daniel Khashabi.

EMNLP 2026 Findings.

The Flaw of Averages: Quantifying Uniformity of Performance on Benchmarks [\[Paper\]](#)

Arda Uzunoglu, **Tianjian Li**, Daniel Khashabi.

EMNLP 2026.

The Translation Barrier Hypothesis: Multilingual Generation with Large Language Models Suffers from Implicit Translation Failure [\[Paper\]](#)

Niyati Bafna, **Tianjian Li**, Kenton Murray, David R. Mortensen, David Yarowsky, Hale Sirin, Daniel Khashabi.

AAACL 2025.

Benchmarking Language Model Creativity: A Case Study on Code Generation [\[Paper\]](#)[\[Code\]](#)[\[Video\]](#)

Yining Lu, Dixuan Wang, **Tianjian Li**, Dongwei Jiang, Sanjeev Khudanpur, Meng Jiang, Daniel Khashabi.

NAACL 2025.

Verifiable by Design: Aligning Language Models to Quote from Pre-Training Data [\[Paper\]](#)[\[Code\]](#)[\[Video\]](#)

Jingyu Zhang, Marc Marone, **Tianjian Li**, Benjamin Van Durme, Daniel Khashabi.

NAACL 2025. **Oral Presentation**.

Technologies

Languages: Python, C++, Java, Shell Script.

Frameworks and Tools: Linux, PyTorch, HuggingFace, Inference Engines (vLLM, SgLang), RL frameworks (verl, slime, prime-rl), Distributed Training (FSDP, Megatron-LM, DeepSpeed), vim, Latex.

Awards

National Olympiad in Informatics Provinces (NOIP) First Prize. 2015

Invited Talks

Beijing Academy of Artificial Intelligence (BAAI) Dec 2025

Johns Hopkins University, CLSP Seminar Spring 2024

Service

Reviewer for —

- NLP Conferences: ACL (2023, 2024, 2025), EMNLP (2023, 2024, 2025), NAACL (2025), EACL (2024, 2025), COLM (2024, 2025, 2026).
- ML Conferences: ICLR (2025, 2026), NeurIPS (2025), ICML (2026).

Organizer: Mid-Atlantic Student Colloquium on Speech, Language and Learning (2024)

Teaching

Head Teaching Assistant, JHU CS 601.471/671 NLP: Self-supervised Models Spring 2025

- Gave lectures on distributed training: [\[Video 1\]](#)[\[Video 2\]](#)

Course Assistant, JHU CS 601.471/671 NLP: Self-supervised Models Spring 2024